south India. Parpola has highlighted ‘Dravidian loanwords in the Vedic language, including the oldest available source, the Rigveda’.[39]

In short, independent evidence from three disciplines—linguistics, archaeology, genetics—now makes it fairly certain that the Harappans spoke one or more proto-Dravidian languages (and possibly other languages; they inhabited a large region). Their collapse in the northwest was followed by the third major influx of migrants into the subcontinent, of a people who called themselves Aryans. Never in their wildest dreams could these Aryans have imagined that they’d be the source of so many incendiary debates and culture wars 3500 years later!

The Aftermath of the Harappan Civilization

Harappan seals, pottery, figurines and animal bones reveal many real and mythical animals—dog, tiger, birds, wild ass, ‘unicorn, humped bull, elephant, rhinoceros, water buffalo, short-horned humpless bull, goat, antelope, crocodile and hare’[40]—but not horse, one-humped camel or donkey. The horse appears in the subcontinent *after* the collapse of the Harappan Civilization. It likely arrived in numbers along with the Aryans from Central Asia, a horse-riding nomadic–pastoralist people with perhaps some knowledge of crops. What also accompanied them was their language and religion: proto-Sanskrit, proto-Vedas and Vedic gods—mostly male gods, such as Indra, Agni, Mitra, Varuna, Rudra and Surya, and a few female gods, such as Usha and Prithvi. They used iron, revered fire and the cow (though they also slaughtered it and ate beef),[41] and preferred cremating the dead. By the time these Aryan herders entered the subcontinent—in the middle centuries of the second millennium BCE—urban Harappans had largely dissolved into rural life.

Notably, the Vedic lore of the Aryans mentions defensive armour, weapons, chariots and warfare against dark-skinned foes named Dasas. But the Dasas were not Harappans, who no longer lived in fortified cities by the time the Aryans reached the Indus Valley. Based on the styles of Dasa forts described in the Rig Veda, Parpola and others have argued that the Dasas were proto-Sakas, a pastoralist group of the Central Asian steppes, and ‘the major fights between the Aryans and the Dasas probably took place not in